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Research proposal

Astral customer discovery
Draft for review · October 2026

Research proposal



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Why the work is needed

Why the work is needed

We want to run a research-led discovery with IMSERV customers. Today we are designing Astral without evidence of how customers actually do their energy-data work.

Where this stands

Clive has offered to help unlock customer access. He has **not** agreed a research plan, scope, or sample size. This proposal is for that conversation.

The research repository has no studies, insights, archetypes, or experience scores yet.

What we risk without it

Designing for assumptions that have not been tested with customers, such as which working hats exist, what reporting means, and whether problems sit in the interface or in the service behind it.

NOT A FINDING YET

Everything here is a proposed approach. None of it is a finding about IMSERV customers yet.

What we already know

Every item has a source and a limit. Most of it is an internal account of customer behaviour, not observed with customers.

Evidence	Source	Limit
Clive and Emily Haddon did a dozen or more customer interviews. The notes sit with Clive	Work Desk notes, 4 Sep 2026	We have not seen the notes. We do not know who was interviewed or what was asked
British Gas and Scottish Water asked to take part in the beta	Work Desk notes, 4 Sep 2026	A route to customers. Not a sample
Customers want to see their own estate, know meters are working, get invoices and reports, and follow problems. Export is more common than looking at graphs	Max Lake, DataVision walk, 4 Sep 2026	Internal account of customer behaviour. Not observed with customers
People pick sites and meters, compare them, then export a file. They do not browse the whole portfolio	Max Lake, 4 Sep 2026	As above
Company types are Customer, Broker / TPI, Supplier, and Platform admin. A Customer has Energy, Finance, Asset, and Data working hats	IMSERV customer base, desk research, 12 Sep 2026	Public-page desk research. Not a study
Access has three separate parts: what the company bought, the person's role, and which sites and documents they can see	Astral product model, 22 Sep 2026	From the handoff transcript. The role matrix is still open
Large customers narrow from the whole portfolio, to a region, to sites, to one MPAN. One customer has about 8,000 MPANs	As above	Named in a talk. Not observed

Assumed and not yet known

Beliefs we have not tested with customers, and the gaps that matter to the decision.

ASSUMED

- The Energy, Finance, Asset, and Data hats describe how people work. They are a useful recruitment start. They may not be four archetypes.
- Customers mostly use Astral for reporting. Reporting may mean pulling data that is finished somewhere else.
- The people a senior contact introduces us to are the people who do the day-to-day work.
- Problems people raise about the portal are interface problems. Some may be service, process, or data-quality problems.

UNKNOWN

- Who actually logs in today and who just receives a file.
- What starts the work, what people check before they trust a figure, and where the work leaves the portal.
- Who does the work, who approves it, and who receives the result.
- Which behaviour patterns recur across organisations and roles.
- How often those patterns happen across a wider set of customers.
- Where the journey breaks down, and whether the cause is the interface or the service behind it.

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Our goals

Our goals

The discovery should produce three things.

BEHAVIOURAL ARCHETYPES

How people actually work, what they need, and what changes the design.

CUSTOMER JOURNEYS

Evidence-backed. What happens today, including work outside Astral.

PRIORITISED UX DECISIONS

Each one traceable to evidence, and ready for the BA team to turn into stories.

Decisions it should inform

- Which customer tasks and journeys Astral should prioritise for version one and after.
- Which behavioural differences need different designs, defaults, or trade-offs.
- Where problems sit in the service and process, not the interface. So we do not try to fix ownership or data quality with screen copy.
- What the BA team should specify next, with evidence behind each story.

Supporting questions

- What triggers the work, and what does finished look like?
- What do people check before they rely on a figure or share a report?
- Where does work leave Astral or DataVision, and why?
- Who contributes, approves, or acts, and what information do they need?
- Where does the work slow down, and what happens when it goes wrong?
- Which patterns recur across organisations, roles, and scales?

PRIMARY RESEARCH QUESTION

How do IMSERV customers do their energy-data work today, and which differences in that work should change how Astral is designed and prioritised?

Objectives

Seven objectives. Each has a research question, the activity that answers it, the evidence, and a measure. Measures serve an objective. They are not collected for their own sake.

Objective	Research question	Activity	Evidence	Measure
1. Understand how customers do their energy-data work today, from trigger to finished outcome, including spreadsheets, email, and other tools.	What triggers the work, and what does finished look like?	Discovery interviews, walkthroughs	Episode accounts, artefacts	Journey stages covered per scenario
2. Identify recurring behavioural patterns that need different design priorities or trade-offs.	Which patterns recur across organisations, roles, and scales?	Rounds 1 and 2, integration	Coded episodes across participants and organisations	Patterns observed in n of N participants and organisations
3. Understand what people check before they trust and share a figure or a report.	What do people check before relying on a figure?	Interviews, walkthroughs, survey	Described and shown checks. Reported frequency	Reported frequency among respondents
4. Identify who does, approves, and receives the work, and where handoffs and waiting happen.	Who contributes, approves, or acts?	Interviews, walkthroughs	Handoffs, correspondence	Handoffs per journey. Waiting points
5. Determine where problems come from the service, process, or data rather than the interface.	Where does it slow down, and why?	Walkthroughs, support evidence, blueprint	Breakdowns traced to cause	Problems classed interface, process, or data
6. Gauge how often the patterns from interviews happen across a wider group of respondents.	How often do these patterns happen?	Survey	Responses	Share of respondents, by people and by organisation
7. Evaluate whether proposed design changes address the needs we find.	Do proposed changes meet the need?	Design implication testing	Observed tasks	Task success, effort, confidence

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What we propose

Review existing evidence → interview and observe → find provisional patterns → survey those patterns → follow up on contradictions → refine archetypes and journeys → test design implications.

Approach

An exploratory sequential mixed-methods discovery. Qualitative research comes first. It sets the concepts and language that the survey then measures.

Connected, not just collected

Interviews build the survey. Survey results guide follow-up recruitment. Both are compared in one analysis (Fetters, Curry and Creswell).

A **short screener** is still used for recruitment. That is different from the main survey.

Archetypes, not decorative personas

We will define research-backed behavioural profiles and customer journeys. The profiles do the job of personas, without fictional biographies.

Archetypes come from recurring patterns. They are not job titles with a new label.

Seven stages

Two of them have their own plan and script: the interviews and the survey.

STAGE 1

Agree scope and decisions

Agree what the research must help decide, the priority journeys, and what is out of scope.

1 to 2 weeks

STAGE 2

Set up recruitment

Reach the people who actually do the work, across several organisations.

2 to 3 weeks, alongside stage 1 · See the interview plan

STAGE 3

Discovery round 1

Understand real, recent episodes of work before showing any proposed screens.

2 to 3 weeks, including analysis · See the interview plan

STAGE 4

Discovery round 2, targeted

Fill the gaps round 1 found and test our early interpretations.

2 to 3 weeks, including analysis · See the interview plan

STAGE 5

Survey pilot and run

Gauge how often the patterns from discovery happen across a wider group of respondents.

3 to 4 weeks · See the survey plan

STAGE 6

Integrate and follow up

Bring the evidence together, investigate disagreement, and refine archetypes and journeys.

About 2 weeks · See the survey plan

STAGE 7

Test design implications

Check whether proposed changes address the needs we found.

2 to 3 weeks

OVERALL

12 to 18 weeks

With overlap, from agreement to tested implications.

What the research produces

Current state and future proposals stay visibly separate.

BEHAVIOURAL ARCHETYPES

- Recurring goals and situations
- Working strategies and information needs
- Constraints, handoffs, and difficulties
- Design implications
- Supporting evidence and known exceptions

We do not decide the number in advance.

CUSTOMER JOURNEYS

- Start with the current experience, including work outside Astral
- Go deep on two or three priority scenarios
- Actor, trigger, outcome, stages, handoffs, waiting, and exceptions
- A service blueprint for cross-department issues

PRIORITISED UX DECISIONS

- Each follows one chain, so it stays traceable into BA work
- Observation, interpretation, and recommendation stay separate

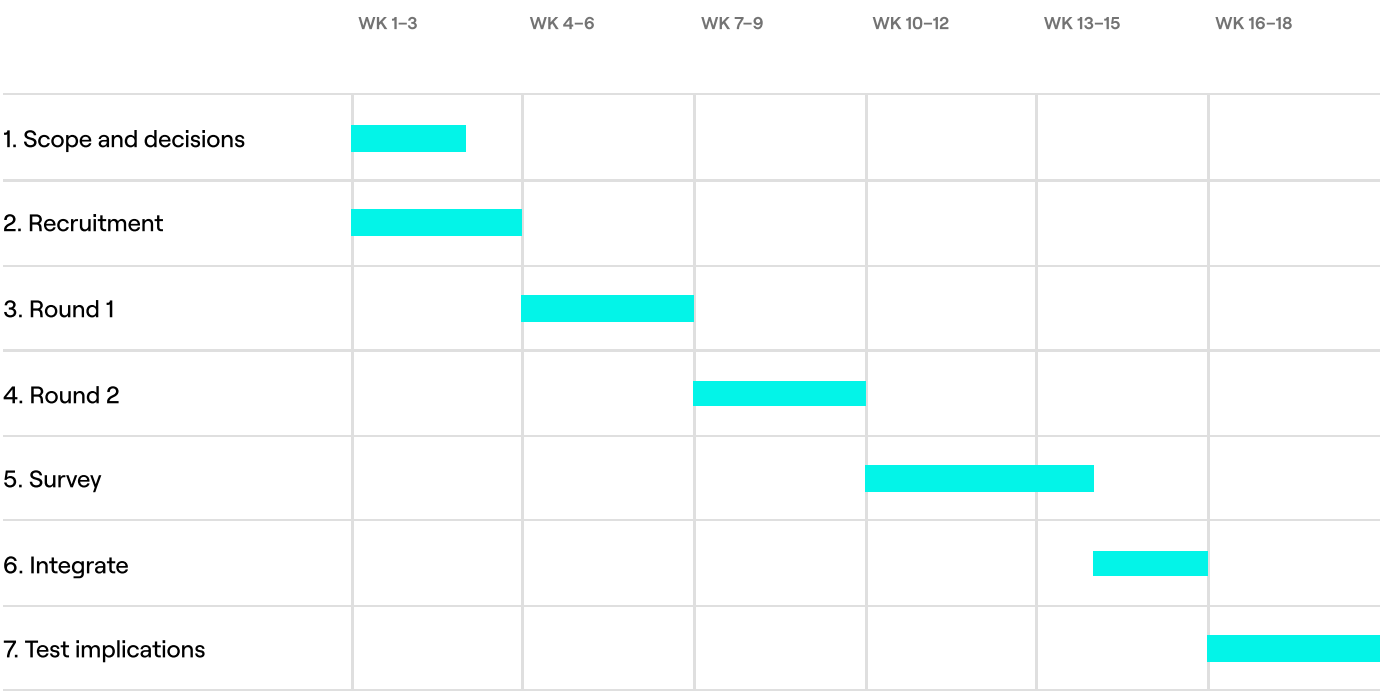
STEP 1 Evidence	STEP 2 User need	STEP 3 Journey problem
STEP 4 Design hypothesis	STEP 5 Story and acceptance criteria	STEP 6 Evaluation

THE TEST FOR EVERY ARCHETYPE

Would this profile change how we design, prioritise, or evaluate a real task?

Provisional timeline

Estimates to agree, not commitments. Bars show the upper estimate for each stage. With overlap, roughly 12 to 18 weeks from agreement to tested implications.



Stage	Provisional duration	Depends on
1. Agree scope and decisions	1 to 2 weeks	Time with Clive and the manager. Access to existing interview notes
2. Set up recruitment	2 to 3 weeks, alongside stage 1	Access coordinator. Privacy owner sign-off
3. Discovery round 1	2 to 3 weeks, including analysis	Bookings
4. Discovery round 2, targeted	2 to 3 weeks, including analysis	Gap recruitment
5. Survey pilot and run	3 to 4 weeks	Distribution route. Reachable population known
6. Integrate and follow up	About 2 weeks	Survey results. Follow-up participants
7. Test design implications	2 to 3 weeks	Priority hypotheses. Prototype ready

What we are asking for

Six things we need from reviewers before the research starts.

	Ask	Status
1	**Review this plan** and agree or change the scope, the decisions it supports, and the provisional timeline.	To agree
2	**Agree the first research decisions with Clive.** Which journeys matter most and what is out of scope.	To agree
3	**Name an access coordinator.** Someone who can introduce us to customers and book sessions.	To agree
4	**Access to the people who do the work.** Not only senior account contacts.	To agree
5	**Access to Clive and Emily Haddon's existing customer interview notes.** So we build on them, not repeat them.	To agree
6	**A privacy and data-protection owner.** To agree recording, transcription, storage, and any AI processing before the first session.	To agree

Working alongside the BA team

- Round 1 findings are shared with the BA team as they emerge, marked provisional
- Stories link back to the need and evidence behind them
- The BA team (Claire and others) can bring open story questions into round 2

The other two documents

- **Interview plan and script.** How the discovery interviews run, who takes part, and the script, with every question tied to an objective.
- **Survey plan and script.** How the survey is built, piloted, and analysed, and the draft questions with their routing, each tied to an objective.

Neutral draft. No consent wording is sent until it is approved. Legal review before it reaches a participant.

Consent, privacy and data

Agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session.

Every session

- Informed consent for every participant before the session
- Recording, transcription, storage, retention, and any AI processing agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session
- Approved storage with restricted access. Raw recordings and transcripts stay restricted
- Customer documents shown in walkthroughs are redacted or not kept, as agreed
- Participants are P01, P02 in analysis. Removing names alone may not anonymise a distinctive business account
- Quotes in shared outputs only with consent for anonymised quotation
- No consent wording is sent until it is approved. The current wording is a neutral draft

How AI is used

Copilot can help organise approved material, suggest candidate patterns, and keep evidence links up to date. Only within what the privacy owner approves.

It will **not** invent quotes, build archetypes from job titles, or treat simulated customers as evidence.

Risks and limits

What could weaken the evidence, and what we do about it.

Risk	Effect	Mitigation
Introductions only reach senior contacts	We hear about the work, not from the people doing it	Ask for practitioners by the activity they do. Track who does what in the screener
Participants come from one or two organisations	Shared local process looks like a pattern	Track organisation coverage. Recruit across several
Recruitment or privacy approval is slow	The timeline moves	Start both in stage 1. Share early findings from round 1
Existing interview notes are not available	We repeat work, or miss context	Ask Clive early. Record what they cover
The survey reaches only engaged customers	Patterns look more common than they are	Report respondents, not customers. Name the sampling limits
Prototype screens steer discovery	We confirm our own design	No screens until stage 7
Archetypes are expected before evidence exists	A persona deck without support	Agree upfront that archetypes emerge from rounds 1 and 2
Twelve interviews are treated as enough	A multi-role audience is under-covered	Plan rounds, not a total. Keep recruiting while important gaps remain



Thank You

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